



AUSTRIA

Capital city: Vienna

Area: 32,378 sq miles
(83,858 sq km)

Population: 8,100,000

Official language:
German

Major religions:
Christian 83%,
Muslim 2%, other 1%

Government: Multiparty
democracy

Currency: Euro

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 79 years

People per doctor: 312

Televisions: 516 per
1,000 people

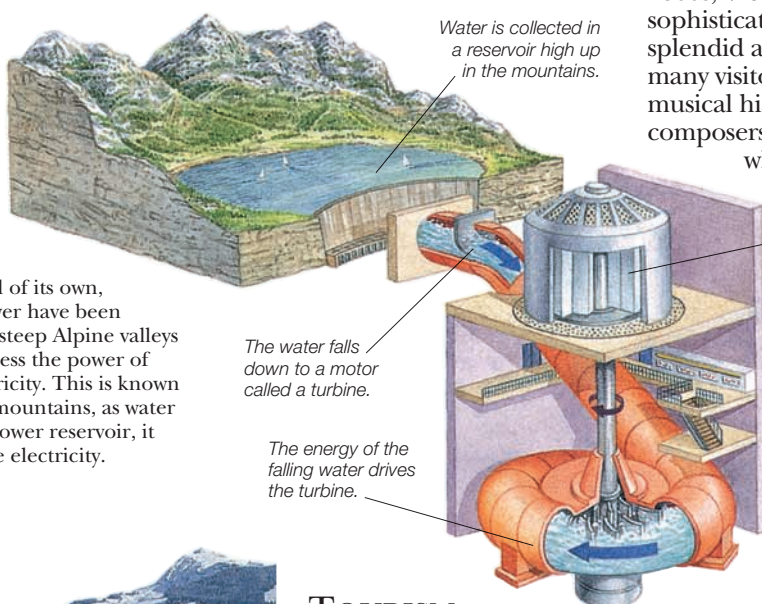
AUSTRIA

THE SMALL, MOUNTAINOUS republic of Austria was once the center of the vast Austro-Hungarian empire. It first became an independent country in 1918. The Alps cover much of western Austria and fertile lowlands stretch across the east. Dairy herds graze on the mountain slopes and crops such as cereals and fruit grow well in the north. Modern-day Austria is an industrialized nation, with cities such as Linz producing iron, steel, heavy engineering, and chemicals. Austria joined the European Union in 1995.



VIENNA

Austria's capital city was once the glittering capital of the Austro-Hungarian empire, and the palace (above) was the residence of its emperors. In the late 1700s and 1800s, Vienna was one of the most sophisticated cities in Europe. Today, the splendid architecture from that era attracts many visitors. Others come to soak up musical history – the city was a magnet for composers, such as Mozart and Beethoven, who hoped to win commissions from the aristocracy.



Water is collected in a reservoir high up in the mountains.

The water falls down to a motor called a turbine.

The energy of the falling water drives the turbine.

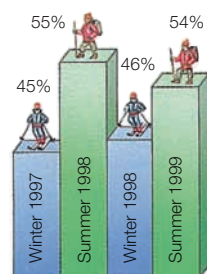
The movement of the turbine drives an electricity generator.

Steep roofs are built to shed heavy winter snowfalls.

HYDROELECTRIC POWER

Austria has little coal and no oil of its own, so other ways of producing power have been developed. Plentiful rivers and steep Alpine valleys provide an opportunity to harness the power of moving water to generate electricity. This is known as hydroelectric power. In the mountains, as water is released from an upper to a lower reservoir, it powers generators that produce electricity.

Tourism in the Austrian Alps



This chart shows the percentage of tourists visiting Austria in the winter or summer. Winter visitors go skiing; summer visitors go hiking.



TOURISM

Tourism accounts for nearly 20 percent of the country's income. In addition to exploring Austria's historic cities, visitors come to go skiing and hiking. Some of the world's best ski resorts are found here, and favorite summer haunts include the huge lakes nestling in the Alps. Conservation measures are being introduced to protect the land from damage by large numbers of visitors.

Austrians drink their coffee with milk, whipped cream, or strong and black.



VARIED FOOD

Viennese coffee houses are famous worldwide for their vast selection of coffee, cakes, and pastries. Austrian food blends a range of influences – the result of all the different countries that once fell within the empire. For example, the famous *Wiener Schnitzel* (Viennese cutlet) – a breaded and fried piece of veal or pork – may have originated in Italy.



MOUNTAIN HOUSES

In the past, Austrian farmers in the Alps built their steep-roofed houses from wood because trees were plentiful. Animals, hay, and humans were often housed in the same building. Hay was kept under the roof; cattle were kept in the basement; and the farmer's family lived in between. This kind of housing can still be seen in some farming villages, although tourism is changing the face of rural areas.

Find out more

ALPINE LANDSCAPE: 106

EUROPEAN UNION: 81, 273

HYDROELECTRIC POWER: 262

DANUBE RIVER: 78